



Suspect charged in Guard shooting

He pleads not guilty to murder, assault and firearms offenses

BY SALVADOR RIZZO AND OLIVIA GEORGE

The man accused of shooting two National Guard members who were patrolling downtown D.C. last week, killing one of them, appeared to study his targets from behind a street corner before ambushing them, yelling “Allahu akbar!” as he shot both victims in the head, according to charging documents filed Tuesday.

Prosecutors disclosed those details at the first court hearing for Rahmanullah Lakanwal, who appeared on a video feed from his hospital bed, wincing in pain as he was formally charged with first-degree murder, assault with intent to kill while armed, and two counts of possessing a firearm during a crime of violence. U.S. Attorney Jeanine Pirro has said more charges are forthcoming.

In documents filed in D.C. Superior Court, prosecutors gave their first detailed account of the midafternoon shooting blocks from the White House. Lakanwal, they said, drove across the country to D.C., armed with a .357-caliber revolver. He studied the National Guard contingent for about one minute, then immediately fired at Spec. Sarah Beckstrom and Staff Sgt. Andrew Wolfe as he turned a corner outside the Farragut West Metro station, prosecutors said.

A supervisor from the National Guard was talking to Beck-

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Vote set on scrapping hepatitis B vaccination

CDC advisers to decide whether to continue practice for all newborns

BY LENA H. SUN

Federal vaccine advisers selected by Health Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr. are planning to vote on ending the practice of vaccinating all newborns for hepatitis B and to examine whether shots on the childhood immunization schedule are behind the rise of allergies and autoimmune disorders, the newly appointed chair of the group told The Washington Post.

Kirk Milhoan, a pediatric cardiologist and critic of coronavirus vaccination who recently took over as chair of the influential vaccine panel, said members meeting on Thursday and Friday are broadly scrutinizing vaccines recommended for children. The wide-ranging discussions on the timing of vaccines and ingredients could signal major changes to how children in the United States are vaccinated, marking the latest flash point in an accelerating

SEE VACCINES ON A6

FDA departure: Top drug regulator to retire weeks after taking job. **A6**



CAROLYN VAN HOUTEN/THE WASHINGTON POST

Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth fields questions Tuesday next to President Donald Trump during a Cabinet meeting at the White House.

U.S. envoys meet Putin in new peace push

BY MARY ILYUSHINA AND ELLEN FRANCIS

A U.S. delegation met with Russian President Vladimir Putin at the Kremlin on Tuesday for high-stakes talks on a revamped peace proposal that the White House is “very optimistic” about amid increased pressure on a weakened Ukraine.

The U.S. delegation for the first time included President Donald Trump’s son-in-law Jared Kushner joining the president’s special envoy, Steve Witkoff, who has been criticized for being too close to

Russians call talks with Witkoff and Kushner on Ukraine ‘productive’

Moscow. They were given a tour of central Moscow by Kirill Dmitriev, a key interlocutor with the Trump administration, before heading to the Kremlin.

The talks went on late into the evening, lasting nearly five hours. “Productive,” Dmitriev wrote in a post on X after they wrapped up

for the night, followed by a dove and olive branch emoji.

“No compromises have been reached yet, and a meeting between the leaders of Russia and the United States is not planned at this time,” Yuri Ushakov, Putin’s top foreign policy aide, told journalists. “We were discussing not specific wording or decisions, but the essence. Both sides see great prospects for cooperation.”

Ushakov added that the talks were “constructive, very useful, and substantive.”

Photos of the meeting shared by Russian state media showed the

group joined by two interpreters and Ushakov in an ornate Kremlin conference room.

The Moscow visit is part of a renewed U.S. push with a new peace proposal. “I think the administration feels very optimistic,” White House press secretary Karoline Leavitt told reporters Monday.

Ahead of the talks, Putin spoke at an investment forum sponsored by VTB Bank, extolling to bankers

SEE RUSSIA ON A11

Security for Kyiv: Past guarantees have meant little in practice. **A12**

Honduras’s ‘narco-state’ president is freed after Trump pardon

BY TOBI RAJI, SHAYNA JACOBS, SAMANTHA SCHMIDT AND DEREK HAWKINS

Former Honduran president Juan Orlando Hernández, convicted by a U.S. court last year on charges that he ran the Central American nation as a “narco-state” that helped send South

American cocaine to the United States, has been released from federal prison after receiving a “full and unconditional” pardon from President Donald Trump.

Hernández, 57, was released Monday from U.S. Penitentiary Hazelton in West Virginia, according to the Federal Bureau of Prisons website and a BOP spokesperson.

Hernández, who was president of Honduras from 2014 to 2022, was serving 45 years in prison on importation and weapons charges. U.S. prosecutors said he built his political career on millions of dollars in bribes from traffickers in Honduras and Mexico, and as president helped to move at least 400 tons of cocaine to the United States while protecting traffick-

ers from extradition and prosecution.

The Trump administration is waging what it says is a counter-narcotics campaign off Venezuela. U.S. forces have destroyed at least 21 boats in the Caribbean Sea and Pacific Ocean, killing more than 80 people, that officials say were carrying drugs to the U.S., and U.S. troops and war-

ships are massing in the region. Trump has accused Venezuelan President Nicolás Maduro of sending violent criminals and drugs to the U.S.

But on Friday, Trump said that Hernández had been “treated very harshly and unfairly” and that he would grant him a “Full and Complete Pardon.”

SEE HERNANDEZ ON A12

Drizzles in the Big Apple



CHARLY TRIBALLEAU/AFP/GETTY IMAGES

Umbrella-toting pedestrians walk through a rainy New York City on Tuesday. A winter storm underway in the eastern United States will keep the Mid-Atlantic rainy, while New England is likely to see snowfall.

Delays on limiting plastic left enormous health toll

For decades, U.S. regulatory agencies failed to act decisively on scientists’ concerns about phthalates

BY JAKE SPRING

CARY, N.C. — Earl Gray was astonished by what he found when he cut into the laboratory rats. Some had testicles that were malformed, filled with fluid, missing or in the wrong place. Others had shriveled tubes blocking the flow of sperm, while still more were missing glands that help produce semen.

For months, Gray and his team had been feeding rats corn oil laced with phthalates, a class of chemical widely used to make plastics soft and pliable. Working for the Environmental Protection Agency in the early 1980s, Gray was evaluating how toxic substances damage the reproductive system and tested dibutyl phthalate after reading some early papers suggesting it posed a risk to

human health.

Sitting on a screened porch on a humid summer day more than 40 years later, Gray recalled the study and the grisly birth defects. “It was in enough animals, so we knew it wasn’t random malformations,” said Gray, 80, who retired after nearly 50 years with the agency.

Gray and other scientists were awakening to the potential dangers of phthalates, which were making their way into nearly every human being on the planet as plastics became a way of life in the 20th century.

Yet even as the dangers became more evident, the Food and Drug Administration, the EPA and other regulators made only piecemeal efforts to limit their use over the next 50 years. This inaction

SEE PLASTIC ON A8

IN THE NEWS

‘Trump accounts’ pledge The CEO of Dell Technologies and his wife said they will donate \$6.25 billion to seed investment vehicles for millions of American children. **A2**

A World War II weapon The Holocaust Museum has acquired the pen that was used to help save twins at Auschwitz. **B13**

THE NATION **The high court** seemed sympathetic to an anti-abortion group in a fight over donor names. **A4** **Blue states** that don’t provide SNAP data to the U.S. government could lose funding. **A13**

THE WORLD **Leo XIV** urged peace in the Mideast and Venezuela as he ended his first foreign trip. **A10** **The E.U.’s former** foreign policy chief was detained amid a fraud investigation. **A11**

THE ECONOMY **Retail giant Costco** is suing the Trump administration over tariffs and is seeking a refund of duties it has paid. **A4** **Holiday shoppers** are using “buy now, pay later” services to spread out payments and shop more strategically, data shows. **A14**

STYLE **Quarter-zips**, a look associated with suburban dads and tech bros, are being embraced by young Black men. **B1**

SPORTS **Ryan Rollins’s time** with the Wizards ended ignominiously. Now he’s emerging with the Milwaukee Bucks. **B7**

THE REGION **Va. budget analysts** say federal actions and economic forces might bring lean times to a state that has enjoyed years of surplus. **B13**

FOOD **Ready for a food fight?** See how readers voted in our online quiz involving recipe ingredients.

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